

features ■ service and reliability survey

least three years. As Hitesh Gupta, a student using both Samsung and Seagate hard disks pointed out, "There seems to be a generic problem with the Samsung hard disk developing bad sectors. However, the three-year warranty provides a

A Seagate hard disk was owned longer than a Samsung, and needed a greater amount of servicing in a two-year period

good platform." Seagate was held back on this front with complaints of "One-year warranty not a sufficient time period", or "product is good, but not enough warranty". As one Devinder Singh echoes, "A three-year warranty given by a company assures reliability of its product. A consumer then looks for a quality product instead of seeking after-purchase services from the company."

Our readers also expressed dissatisfaction with the after-sales service offered by Seagate, once the warranty expires. As Prakash Dugar, a chartered accountant,

claims, "Beyond the warranty period of one year, Seagate provides no service support, one has to simply throw away the product and buy a new one." A charge supported by Pratima Sawe a computer consultant: "When the hard disk stops working after the warranty period expires, Seagate refuses to give repair support. The company should undertake repairs and charge for it." Samsung is not without sin in this regard as one particular reader pointed out that "Whenever I call a service centre, they tell me to call after 10 to 15 days".

MOST RELIABLE HARD DISKS: Samsung RUNNER-UP: Seagate
MOST SATISFACTORY SERVICE: Samsung RUNNER-UP: Seagate

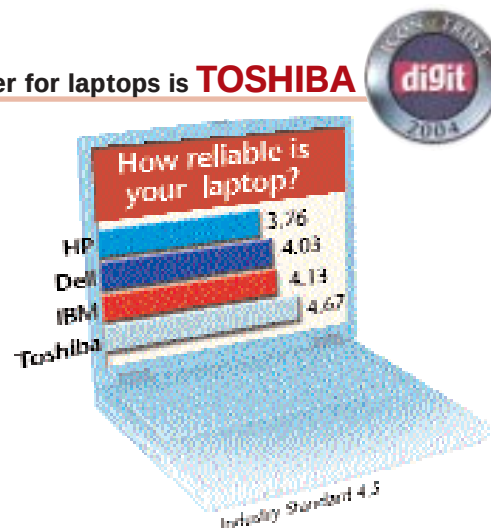
Laptops

Winner for laptops is **TOSHIBA**

The woe of most desktop computers users is the fact that the tool of their trade and entertainment is no symbol of reliability. Its portable counter-part—the laptop—can be safely considered a bonsai version of the desktop behemoths. Logically thus, one could surmise that laptops would also suffer the family curse of mal-reliance and instability. However, we learned, with humility, that one can only stretch logic this far, before it comes snapping

back, reality in tow.

Based on our consumer survey, we found that laptops did pretty well indeed, both in terms of reliability and overall service. A part of this could be because only 170 responses were logged for this section; only MP3 players had smaller representation. Nevertheless, everyone responding was pretty happy with their purchases—solutions from HP, Dell, IBM and Toshiba—in terms of perform-

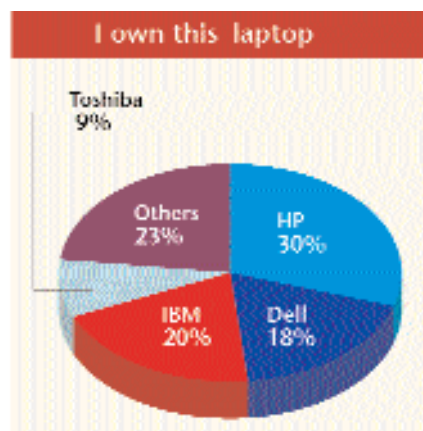


What I am really impressed by is the speed at which these buggers work

Hiten Sampat, on his IBM laptop
Mumbai, Maharashtra

tle surprise when the manufacturer Dell scored the highest on our Service Index for laptops.

A surprise was, however, sprung by Toshiba: this particular company seems to enjoy a good rapport with its laptop users. One particular IT professional was



ance of their machines, their reliability and the after-sales support provided by their manufacturers.

Arvind Krishnan, who would only identify himself as an administrator, was particularly upbeat about his Dell laptop, pointing out that they offer, "very good after-sales service. A faulty part was replaced within 24 hours, even though the part had to come over from Bangalore." Jyoti Chakravartty supports his case and Dell's by saying, "The service was prompt and the person from Dell was really friendly." With similar responses across the board, it came as lit-

Dell's technical staff came up on top, whereas HP's did the worst. Respondents were most satisfied with IBM when it came to repair or replacement of their unit